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Neal Caine

Bassist Neal Caine has the ability to share the bandstand with Elvin Jones, Harry Connick and Betty Carter. His writing is featured on the CD release "Backstabber's Ball."

Neal was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on September 26, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Neal Caine here, bassist and, you just got a big compliment from David Torkanowsky about a Frank Sinatra 100th birthday observance, a big band. And he said you really kicked some butt with your bass that night.

NC: Wow. That's great.

MR: And the reason it came up was I asked him this question, I'm going to ask you too. In a jazz small group is it the bassist or the drummer who's more responsible for the time?

NC: Well you know ideally it should be everybody, but due to the importance of the bass and the drums it pretty much falls on us. Because horn players can kind of float around and nobody even really notices. I think it's kind of both. I mean the drums obviously controls the percussion and stuff, but the bass is the nexus of rhythm and harmony. And honestly, I think the bass has a lot of control, more control than most people realize, over where the music goes, and it's a lot more subtle. If I decide to go to a two beat or a four beat, or, I can control what happens. And also I've noticed over the years, I noticed that when I had a bad night the band kind of had a bad night. And if I had a good night, the whole band had a good night. Generally speaking.

MR: What would constitute — what reason might you have a bad night?

NC: Dude you know I've been asking myself that for so long. You know it's like I mean first of all jazz music is hard and a lot of things go into it, especially if you're really playing honestly and you're not relying on contrived things or patterns. If you're really in the moment, you know, sometimes you have a good day, sometimes you have a bad day. Personally I don't know, I think it has to do with anything from music to how your day went and your personal life, how you're feeling. I know me, I try to now really, when I'm having those moments I try to acknowledge it, okay, this, I'm having a shitty night like now. What can I do about it? That's where I am right now. But honestly it's hard, man, I wish I knew. I think the better you get, the variance between a good night and a bad night gets smaller. But hell, I don't know.

MR: Okay I want to go back to something you just said, "jazz music is hard." Some people listen to jazz and feel like well they're just playing anything they want. What's hard

about that? It's almost like looking at a piece of abstract art and saying I could have done that. And you say well you should have then.

NC: Right.

MR: But what is hard about it?

NC: Well because there's tons of — despite what those people think that's just kind of an ill-informed opinion. I mean unless you're playing super free whatever you want, which isn't that easy too, I mean there's tons of rules, I man there's form and there's harmony, I mean, even though we're making it up there's a ton of rules, are you kidding? It's not just I'm going to play Capricorn right now or I'm playing purple or whatever. It's the mix of analytic and emotional you know. That's why it's so hard. It's math and math and harmony and then hopefully some sort of spiritual connection too you know.

MR: Personally I think the bass player is often times the most important cog in the machine, and I feel like there's a lot of — not pressure, but a bass player has to know the tunes. Horn players — I'm a horn player, and you can fake it. You can half know a tune and you can half play the melody and make it like this is my interpretation. Right?

NC: Right.

MR: And if you're hearing the changes you usually can make your way through the thing and not be too embarrassed. But how do you, as a bassist, how have you and how do you get a repertoire of tunes in your memory?

NC: It's hard. I mean other things that advantage horn players and guitar players have is that you know you can fake your way through the melody and then wait for the other guy to solo, and you can hear it. But yeah, beat one I have to do something. It's hard I mean there's a thousand, a million tunes and I don't know them all and even tunes you know, people play them differently. One of my great experiences was playing with Ellis Marsalis when I was in New Orleans and starting out, because I used to do his trio gig every week at Snug, and he would inevitably call a tune he knew you didn't know. And he'd kind of go through it rubato, kind of modern, like some standard. And then he'd just kind of look at you and he'd kind of laugh, 'cause he knew you didn't know it. And he'd go three-four and then you just had to hear your way through it.

MR: Could you stand on the side of the piano so you could see his left hand when possible?

NC: Yeah but at Snug Harbor you couldn't 'cause you were on the other side. I mean I've always just tried to be honest. I mean you hear it and if you can't you drop out or listen or you know, and just wait for your ears to develop. I mean once you accept public humiliation it's like it's pretty easy from there. That's key. You've got to do that.

MR: Once — I want to make sure I got that. Once you accept public humiliation.

NC: Yeah Once you're okay with being made to look like an idiot in front of thousands of people, it's all downhill from there.

MR: Or uphill.

NC: Well yeah, exactly. Depending how you look at it.

MR: That's good. What does a guy like Ellis Marsalis teach you that you might not have learned in the jazz harmony class at Berklee or at any of the universities.

NC: Just that — I mean just gig experience you know? Just playing tunes you don't know on the spot you know, and having to hear it, open up your ears and be able to hear your way through changes. I mean innumerable things. I only went to music school one semester with him so all of my, most of my learning from him was just practical experience. But he was a real father figure, and kind of quiet, strong. He would talk sometimes a lot, but it was more through example and just watching. First of all, he knew a thousand tunes and he just always knew what to play and the right thing. It's hard to put into words. But I only went to music school one semester. I went to Tulane. So I couldn't really speak to the Berklee experience too much.

MR: Do you play with — have you played with music school — jazz school graduates?

NC: Yeah. Most of my peers are —

MR: And do you notice any difference between, well I guess I should ask if you've played with seat-of-the-pants-learning graduates.

NC: Well I mean I was lucky enough to play with Elvin Jones and his band for three or four years, and Betty Carter. And I got to play with Cedar Walton a couple of times, and Ellis Marsalis. I mean you know I don't want to generalize too much because I didn't go to music school. I think a lot of people who go to music school –- it's weird because I'm all for education in general. But it sounds weird to say that maybe not jazz school has messed up jazz but if you do go through that program, which you have to be a real strong individual I think to keep your sense of personality. I hear a lot of my peers, and younger guys, are great musicians, like they all can play their ass off and technically get around, and they know all these tunes. But it's very few I really hear who sound like themselves kind of. And I don't know how much of that is attributed to school. I don't know. I know when you play with like Betty or Elvin or Ellis, it wasn't like we're going to trade fours now and we're going to count it off — you know it was just real life experience stuff, which I wouldn't imagine you could get at a Boston U or whatever, Berklee or whatever school.

MR: Were you in — I don't know if this is the right word, were you intimidated going into the Elvin Jones gig?

NC: You know what's funny? I should have been. I was 21 or 22, and I was so young and ambitious. And I remember like, 'cause it was one of those last second calls. And I flew to Europe and they fired somebody and it was just a real kind of wild story. And I remember, and I was young, and I just remember thinking like I'm not going home. Like

I'm going to get this gig you know. I was — now, if that happened to me now I probably would be scared out of my — but I was too young and dumb to know better.

MR: Because I saw him once in a club and man, he looked furious, and he was sweating. And I was like sort of scared of that energy. So when I read that you played with him — and you followed some good — obviously some fantastic bass players over the years, so I was wondering what that felt like.

NC: Man it was amazing. I mean it was surreal. Because I was young and I was playing with Elvin. And then he was like, "You need to move to New York." And then I'd be at the house hanging out with him and Keiko, you know it was — first of all, even though he's a big guy, when he'd lose his temper it was scary. But it would be about ten seconds and then he'd be like, "Ah I love you" and he'd hug you. So he was actually a very sweet man, very smart guy, quiet, once again, didn't talk that much. But you know like he knew, he was like an expert on Frank Lloyd Wright, and like he like — he had two apartments on Central Park West, and he had like rooms full of books just lined up. Architecture and westerns. He was a very smart, complex, nuanced guy, but I do know what you mean. He was scary at times. He was a big dude.

MR: If an interviewer, you know, got an interview with him and opened the first thing they said was, "Mr. Jones tell us about John Coltrane." How would be react to that?

NC: Well it would probably depend on his mood at that particular moment, but he would say he was an angel. He loved John Coltrane. He was a genius and an angel. I mean he used to talk about, I mean I was lucky enough to spend some time with him and he loved — he used to talk about the Basie band, Duke's band, and then like you know one time I remember we were playing at the New Morning. And it would be like an open bass solo. And I was doing my kind of Jimmy, you know my thing. And my end pin broke. And maybe I stopped for a second and I came off the stage afterwards. And he was mad at me. He was yelling at me, "Why'd you stop?" And I was like, "Man, the bass broke bro." And he was like, "Wilbur Ware played a bass made out of milk cartons." You know like it would be shit like that. I mean it was actually a little more colorful language and all that, but he was a great man. He didn't give a fuck. That's what I mean, the old school, same thing with Betty Carter. They weren't having it man. It was about making sure the music was right. Like there was a certain seriousness — it's hard to translate, and it sounds cliché but it's true, there was a certain seriousness that like Elvin and Betty took that they had about this music, that I don't know that many other people in our generation have. It's actually life and death type shit.

MR: I think I know what you're saying, because I've been fortunate to interview a lot of folks from that generation, and they're serious. And they're always dressed up and they're always a take care of the bandstand type attitude. Why would that change?

NC: I don't know. I mean I don't know if it's a function of our society in general, like we all have Netflix and other things to do. I don't know, it's a good question. I mean I'm not saying people aren't serious about the music now, they are. But like I remember one time after the Betty Carter gig I was like moping. And she goes, "What's wrong with you?" I said, "I didn't think I sounded good tonight. I feel bad about it." She goes, "Good, you should feel bad." Like, "Good, motherfucker you should feel bad." Like this music's important. You know what I'm saying? Like a lot of guys today, and I don't have a great solo career but you know it's about marketing and it's about getting the gig, what hotel. And then the music's about maybe three or four down the list with a lot of people. Not all people. I'm not —

MR: — making a generalization.

NC: Yeah. And that wasn't the case with them I don't think.

MR: Was there a distinction playing behind a vocalist, like Betty Carter? Did she require something different than Elvin Jones did?

NC: In general, yeah. Vocalists do. I mean it's funny, Betty Carter was such a unique vocalist, I always conceptualized her as a sax player kind of, in a way. When I thought about her like that it made more sense to me. She was great, man. She was so challenging. Because she had a lot of different forms and speeds and a lot of it was kind of cues to the next section and they'd be different every night. So in that respect it wasn't the usual just play a standard kind of singer. But yeah, I mean I played with Diana Krall and I played with Harry Connick and when you play standards with singers you have to really play the right notes. You have to really know the changes. And you have to be really aware of what you're playing and how it affects the singer, and not get in their way, and be supportive. You know if I'm playing a standard with a tenor player you can fudge, you can play some different things you know. But you have to be really much more in tune and you have to play the right changes. It's different. It's a little harder I think.

MR: Do you have a thought method that kicks in if you have to play "There Will Never Be Another You" in A flat instead of E flat?

NC: No.

MR: Okay.

NC: I mean you know what? No matter if it's a singer or whatever situation it is, whatever song, whatever key, whether it's Elvin Jones or Diana Krall, I just try to play the right thing. I mean it's really actually simple. I mean it's really hard but there's always a right thing to play. That's what a lot of rhythm section people, it's like there's an obvious thing to play that feels right at that time, and that's appropriate, whatever the situation may be. I always just try to find that.

MR: I'm not that informed about current creative jazz, but much of it I hear, what I have heard, sounds like the bass player and the drummer are playing with the time, playing with the time, rather than playing the time, if that makes sense.

NC: Yeah I know what you mean.

MR: And I find it challenging to figure out. That' just my personal thing. But do you know what I'm talking about?

NC: I do know what you mean. I mean you know that's another reason this music's so hard, because you have to learn how to play it, you have to get the tools and the technique and the songs and the sound and everything that you're required to do it, and then you have to apply it. I mean I'm not going to name names, but we both know a lot of great musicians who are really great but you can't stand what they're doing. You know like it's stupid. Or whatever. Whatever you think. Or I shouldn't say stupid, but it's too busy, or they've lost the essence of the song. I mean you have to be swinging and grooving first, and I like complex stuff, but it's got to be applied correctly you know. I always just equate rhythm section playing to a conversation. I mean all jazz, I mean it sounds maybe Ken Burnsish but it's true. I mean if we're talking right now and I start talking real fast and start saying all types of crazy stuff, it doesn't make sense. And I think that's what you mean with these drummers' problem.

MR: Yeah. And if I can't feel a pulse from somebody I guess I get uneasy.

NC: Yeah. What's the point? What's the point, man."

MR: It don't mean a thing if, whoever said that.

NC: Exactly.

MR: Did you have a moment growing up that you can recall where the music really made an impression on you and led you down this path?

NC: Well I was playing violin at a young age, like three or four, the Suzuki method of classical music and stuff. And I grew up in St. Louis, and I was lucky enough to grow up in an area, University City, well the Cleetown first and then U City, and like some of the guys a little older than me were playing jazz. Like Todd Williams played with Wynton Marsalis, and Peter Martin plays piano with Diane Reeves, and Chris Thomas, a great bass player. And Todd was in Wynton's band, so this was probably like the late 80s. So Wynton and them would come around, like when I was in high school and I kind of got into it that way. But I mean I loved the music as a kid. My mom had records. I can remember listening to — she had an Ahmad Jamal record and some Miles Davis records and the Trumpet Kings record, the Montreux. So it was around the house. But it took me a minute to really decide to be a musician you know, because I went to Tulane and was just going to be a regular person kind of.

MR: You were just going to be a —

NC: Yeah, a civilian. Yeah. Something happened and I got sidetracked and here I am, 25 years later.

MR: Have you ever regretted it?

NC: Not really. It took me a minute. I used to say like oh yeah, I was going to be a lawyer. And then after a couple of years it was like no you aren't. You're a musician.

MR: And how did your mother feel about your going into it?

NC: Well I went to Tulane and then I started playing with Delfeayo Marsalis. And it was my freshman year, and I had my finals and Delfeayo had like a tour in Europe like two months. So I had to decide like am I going to — so after [inaudible] I just went. I like dropped out of school. My mother wasn't happy about it but she is a great woman. She said, "You shouldn't do it but if you do I'll support you." And now she wants like thirty tickets every show I do.

MR: Yeah. Nice. Tell me about, I know you're a composer too. And also you have great titles. This collection you had, "Backstabber's Ball."

NC: You like that?

MR: Very distinctive.

NC: Not too dark, huh?

MR: And "The Hempire Strikes Back."

NC: Yeah, there's a little collegiate in me yet.

MR: Your titles are — sometimes it's hard to name instrumental tunes.

NC: It's very hard. I struggle with that, yeah. Yeah I don't know, it's hard. I'm glad you like those titles. Some people don't like them.

MR: Really.

NC: Yeah.

MR: Because a title can put a spin on something that maybe doesn't deserve a spin.

NC: It's true. I mean sometimes you have a theme in mind or a title and you write the song to the title. But a lot of times I'll just write a tune and then you have to —

MR: Do you sit at a piano? Do you write it from the bass? Do you just write it in your head?

NC: You know it's weird. I kind of do all of that. And usually, I don't really have any kind of system. Usually I'll think of something — sometimes I'll think of a groove, a bass line, and start it from there on the bass. And then sometimes I'll start on the piano and have a theme and then a lot of times I'll write something and then kind of put it down and then — or write it and then come back to it and then fix it. It's a lot of — it takes me — very rarely do I just have a tune clear throughout the whole head. Sometimes I'll have a tune or something, but I'll usually have to mess with it.

MR: Yeah. And then you have to — not have to — and then you get people to play it and what actually comes out may or may not be what you had sort of envisioned.

NC: That's right. That's right. A lot of times it's not. Sometimes it is, usually it's not. And sometimes it's better than you thought, and sometimes it's worse. And like you know I have a sax player who I love who plays in my band sometimes, Stephen Riley. And I'll write like a song with the harmony. And he usually only plays what I write half the time. And sometimes he just does his own thing. And that usually sometimes sounds a lot better. You know I like to keep it open, you know, because you never know what somebody'll add to it.

MR: When you're writing for two tenors, are you like sort of methodical, like all right I'm playing a G sus type bass line and I'm going to give this tenor the third, and this tenor the fifth, or is it a little more just what sounds right. I don't know if that was a —

NC: No, no, no, no. I know what you're saying. No for me it's kind of what sounds right. I mean yeah, I just usually kind of pick notes. Sometimes you know you'll write a melody and then you'll go through and harmonize it, try different ways to do it. But it's really only two voices with the tenors. So I just try to pick pretty notes, really. Sounds kind of simple.

MR: Well that tune was pretty, "The Hempire Strikes Back."

NC: Well thanks, yeah.

MR: And it was sort of visual too. I got this sort of visual thing listening to it. And those tenors were matched, they went well together I thought.

NC: I think so too. They both have pretty sounds.

MR: Yeah.

NC: They're both unique tenor sounds.

MR: Uh huh. Because you could again, replace one of them, and it probably would change the nature of the music some more.

NC: Totally. I mean those guys, Ned Gould and Stephen Riley, they both have pretty sounds. I mean once again, getting back to the school sound, the school thing, a lot of tenor players, as they should, sound like some amalgamation of Wayne Shorter and John Coltrane you know, which is great. I mean that's my favorites. But I like guys who maybe sound a little different you know, than those two.

MR: I can see how that might make you proud or something. If you had a tune like that and you know once the melody is over and then they launch into their solos, all of a sudden it's [scats]. And think of the nature of this song when you're playing. Is it hard — well I think I know the answer to this question but is it hard to find gigs for your own group, keep a cohesive group together?

NC: It is. It is. I mean part of it's because I don't do a lot of the business stuff as much as I should. I kind of have a sideman career. Excuse me. But it is hard because you've got to play. That's one of the things back in the day, those guys played all the time, like long

sets, nightly, and tour. You've got to work stuff out man. Especially when you get in a band, you get on the road, everything comes together. You know if you're playing once a week or once every two weeks it's hard to get continuity with your group. That's a problem I'm having at least.

MR: Yeah. I have a book, it's called the Count Basie Bio-discography. These English jazz researchers man, they find this material. And you look at their itinerary. There's hardly ever a day off, and so that sort of explains why the Great American Rhythm Section, man, they just played so much.

NC: Yeah. Totally. And when you go on a tour with a band and you go out for three weeks or a couple of months, man, yeah, you can see the difference by the end of the tour. It's really tight.

MR: I think Evan mentioned that, Evan Christopher, that you don't play with an amp.

NC: No I don't.

MR: Okay, so tell me about that.

NC: I mean I'm one of the few guys, there's some other guys, but I don't play with an amp, and I play with gut strings. And I do it, well first of all gut strings are really expensive and they go out of tune and they're a pain in the ass. But you know all my favorite bass players, and all everybody else's favorite bass players for the most part played like that. I mean Paul Chambers, Ray Brown back in the day, Milt Hinton, Israel Crosby, Garrison. And look man, I get it. The bass is hard to play and it's quiet. You know? So when steel strings and amps came along it's easier. But it fucking ruined jazz — I won't say it ruined it, you know it allowed for the drummer to play super loud, everyone just turned shit up. Bassists sound electronic with that — you know I just don't like it. I don't like it. And it irks me because people say I'm like some kind of purist or whatever. It's not that. I just think it's much prettier and it allows the drummer to play quiet. And it reminds everyone shut the fuck up please. You can still be loud, but let's keep everything, start here. And I'll get off my soapbox with this last point, what other instrument but maybe the guitar has had an electronic mic added to it in the middle of the history of jazz? Like okay trumpet players, let's just put a pick-up in your trumpet. What would they say? They'd be like hell no. Sax players, they'd be like hell no. I mean you could make it a thing about a guitar maybe you could make that argument, but it doesn't make any sense. In the late 60s all of a sudden they changed the way the bass sounded, which changed the way everything happens.

MR: Boy is that for sure.

NC: So I don't get it. And I'm not saying you know look, I like fusion and all that stuff. But it's a bunch of bullshit in my opinion.

MR: I'm pausing because I think the bass is the most important instrument, and what you're saying makes a lot of sense to me. If you listen to, even in pop music, if you compare how the voice was balanced with the bass back then you could hear the singer. And then you move ahead forty years and all of a sudden the bass is like all of a sudden dominating. Anyway, I think I get what you're saying.

NC: Yeah. And it's like, and look, it's hard for me — like I don't mind not being heard on the loudest, most exciting moments of a song, as a bass player. I'm okay with that. But it just — you know there should be some variance and subtlety. And bass players don't like to admit it either. I've been on the Facebook and these group chats about amps and pick-ups, and it's always like me and two other guys who are like forget a pick-up. But nobody wants to admit — I'm telling you it's just much easier. It's easier to get around. To lower the string you just turn it up. You can play faster, it's easier. It's way harder to get a sound out of the bass, but you know, I'm in the minority, we're in the minority in that respect.

MR: What happens when you travel somewhere and you can't take your own bass?

NC: Well I just deal with — I deal with whatever. I mean I have, I'll say this, now that happens. And if it's a bass that's set up for only an amp, like I'll try to use it acoustically. But some basses you get and the action is this high, and you literally — so there's been probably five to ten times where yeah, I'll go on a gig and I've had to play that bas — and you know it is so fucking easy I sound like Miroslav Vitous, I'm playing all types of crazy shit you know, like Niels Orsted Pederson, I'm all — because it changes the way I approach it too. I don't like it because I like to dig in and swing, and with the pick-up generally, depending on how it's set up it's too easy. So it changes my physicality. So the next thing you know, I'm all flowery and shit. Like I don't like it you know. It's just not for me.

MR: I like your mix of descriptive terms 'cause you've said "pretty" a few times, but you don't necessarily like your bass to be [scats] pretty. You want it to have some natural oomph.

NC: Right. Well pretty can be dark and nasty too, I mean it depends on how you mean pretty. I'm not sure which references I was making. But I want it to be pretty but I want it to be nasty and have some depth to it. And not just frilly.

MR: Okay. No frills.

NC: No frills.

MR: What is your — if you look at your calendar, look at a month in your calendar, as a person who plays as a sideman and then tries to find gigs as a leader. What's it like to be a jazz musician and wear different hats?

NC: Well musically it's fun and challenging. Financially it's like walking a tightrope over a shark pit while juggling on roller skates. But I like the challenge. I've always liked, I've had a pretty wide career as far as different styles. Like I lived in New Orleans I played trad music; I played with Elvin; I've done you know a good amount of work on Broadway, which is a whole 'nother world. So I've always liked the fact that I have had a diverse career. But you know it's a bitch. I mean like you said, we were saying earlier, it's very few bands that work like every day like the Basie — whatever. I'm lucky enough to work with Harry. But that's only a certain amount of work a year, and then you've just got to freelance man, you've got to make it happen. It's not for the weak. You've got to really love the music. I mean even now maybe even more so, because there's less work. You've got to really be in it for the right reasons.

MR: Well thank you for answering the question I didn't ask and that was sort of what does a aspiring jazz musician need, assuming that they're good players. And I think you're saying that you have to just be so into it that you have to do it. Is that a fair statement?

NC: I think so. I mean you know what, in my twenties there were times where — actually at one point I did kind of go I'm going to quit and go back to school. Like when I was maybe 27 or 8, because the travel and the whole thing. I mean but ultimately yeah, I had to do it. I was like this is for me, this really is for me. I have a lot of, I mean you know I was one of the young lions. So that was a time when it was kind of popular again and there was record deals. And there was a bunch of my friends from that era who were good players who, once that period kind of fell off and the realities of this life and the economic instability and you know they became — they did other things. And then some people stayed in it you know. And I think you just really have to love it.

MR: It's interesting that —

NC: I mean it's still a decision — I don't want to extend magical, I mean guys who were born to families with that stuff, that's what they're going to do. But it's not like some magical thing where I had to do it, but ultimately it was the best decision.

MR: Okay. If you look at jazz today and it's thriving in academia, right? Every school, almost every school has a jazz program and summer camps and all that. It doesn't seem to translate into the market, or into the club scene. I wonder what all of the jazz graduates do.

NC: I don't know. They become teachers. I don't know man. I mean yeah, that's a good question. I'm not sure. I didn't go to, once again, I didn't go to school. And I was lucky. I mean I was in the right place at the right time, and took advantage of it. But it's tough out here. I mean if you look at the odds or are logical about it, yeah, it's probably not a good industry to get into you know.

MR: So if you were a guest at one of the larger jazz schools, would you have advice? I want to say it was a gathering of bass players at Berklee, right? And you've been out in the business for years. Do you have anything you can tell them?

NC: I mean I would say, well you know what I did too, I started bass a little late. Like I was a violin teacher, I mean a violin player. And I remember I was like a teenager. And you know Christian McBride's maybe my age, maybe a year or so older. But he was kind of like a hot — I just remember looking at him and some other musicians and being like wow, those bass players are great. Like technically, I don't know if I'm going to be that. So I thought to myself how can I distinguish myself you know. And so I figured oh I'm just going to have the biggest sound out here, I'm going to have the biggest tone and swing the hardest. I would tell those guys to find out what you do good and what you can do to differentiate yourself from the 20,000 other bass players who are playing. I mean besides playing pretty notes and learn changes and be a good bass player. I mean be yourself. It's like everything has been done basically. Right? So my thing is all we can do is be ourselves, like be true artists, really express yourself, your experience. That's what it's about for me.

MR: Yeah, I have often thought that the bass is one of the harder instruments to show a personality. And there's people that stick out in my mind, like Buster Williams, who God almighty, the sound he had. And I don't know if it's just 'cause partly they knew how to record him or something, but.

NC: No. Well they probably did, but it's 'cause he has a unique big ass sound that, you know it's him instantly. Right?

MR: Yeah

NC: I'm sorry, did I interrupt you?

MR: No. So what is the Neal Caine sound?

NC: Well you'll hear it tomorrow.

MR: I will indeed.

NC: I just — you know what it's like, I love I appreciate, like we said there's so many great musicians who know every Paul Chambers solo and John Coltrane solo and can play fast and do this and that. I'm always impressed. But when I hear a musician, whether it be bass or anything, who, they play some, it may be simple, it may even be bad, but I can tell they thought it up, like I can tell it's from them. It's organically from them, or that they believe it. That means a lot and I think the audience knows that. And I think a lot of people don't have that. And I appreciate that. I just like people to be honest. I mean if I want to, you know, like I really respect all these musicians but if I want to go hear — I'll go listen to Charlie Parker you know or Trane or I mean, we all have influences. I'll play

a bunch of Israel Crosby shit that's influenced by him. But I don't know, I just try to be honest. And I think the audiences feel that.

MR: Is there such a thing as playing on top of the beat or behind the beat and still keeping the tempo steady?

NC: Yeah. Generally everybody feels the time kind of where they feel it, and they can coexist. I mean Elvin played so fucking behind and so wide. And even in Harry's band, Arthur Latin, great drummer. We've been playing together for years and years. He kind of plays behind and I kind of play on top a little bit — or in the middle or on top and it works. You know it can work. Yeah.

MR: I remember hearing the drummer Louis Hayes once in a club and he was so on top of the beat I said how does this music not just keep speeding up until it's impossible. And it didn't. But he was like —

NC: Right. Because you can be on top of the beat and not rush. It's about anticipation. Yeah. I don't know, that's an interesting kind of an existential thing, time you know. The concept of time. But I know for me, like I say, I kind of play on top or play in the middle. And generally if I'm with a drummer who plays on top of me it can be uncomfortable. Because sometimes it's better to have the counteract a little bit. I mean it's better to just have it if you were playing right in the middle. But everybody feels it a little different.

MR: What would aggravate you on the bandstand?

NC: Oh I could tell you what aggravates the hell out of me is when drummers play — when they "ghost" the bass drum. When they go [beats] but they do it real fucking loud so it sounds like a polka. And it gets in the way of the bass frequency. That irks me.

MR: Can you define ghost again?

NC: Well you know like drummers, you know like Sam Woodyard with the Basie — I mean with Duke Ellington. Sometimes drummers will lightly play quarter notes on the bass drum. Evidently —

MR: Almost like they're tapping their foot and their foot happens to be on the —

NC: And evidently these guys did it but I never heard it, and guys do it and I never hear it, but a lot of — some drummers do it real loud and so it fucks up — it's really annoying and distracting and it's in the frequency of the bass and it makes it sound like an Army band. So I hate that. I don't know if that's what you were looking for.

MR: Yeah, sure.

NC: That's the first thing I usually like, "Oh God, get off the bass drum bro." I go, "Get off the bass." They go, "Well if you have a balanced drum kit you're supposed to have" — yeah right. Please.

MR: What about piano players who play on the low end an awful lot?

NC: Well once again it depends. You know that's the whole thing about rhythm section players: pianists, bass players and drummers, is we have to accompany, comp, and that's just about being a good person and fitting in and being appropriate you know. It's like you either have band players who play way too much or they don't play at all. Like behind a bass solo I'm saying.

MR: Oh okay.

NC: Behind a bass solo. Or, in general, it's hard man.

MR: When I hear a band and it's time for the bass solo and everybody stops, that wouldn't be my choice if I was the bass player.

NC: Ya think?

MR: I mean, why? I understand that you have to make room for sort of the low frequencies to be heard. But it's almost like a cop out or something.

NC: Yeah. You're damn right. And then when you think about the fact that we spend our whole careers making everyone else sound good on their solos, and then we get our solo and the drummer goes to the hi-hat and the piano player like just fucking sits there. It's infuriating to me.

MR: What would you like to hear? Because well go ahead.

NC: I can tell you what I'd like to hear. Well first of all, everyone's different. I know some bass players who like the hi-hat. First of all you know why bass solos suck? Because there's no bass behind them. I mean it's so basic and so fucking simple. No one ever talks about it. There's no bass behind us, so like if it's a sax solo and he goes [scats] and then he doesn't do anything, it's moving forward, because I'm playing some hip shit hopefully. Now if I'm on a bass solo and I go [scats] nothing is going on. And the one person you want on the ride — he's on the hi-hat. It's like you motherfuckers go play with the hi-hat. Just you play the whole solo with the hi-hat and see how it goes, with no bass. You know it's just fucking infuriating. So for me what I tell drummers to do is treat me like any other soloist, just be a little quieter. Like I like personally I like it when they're on the ride and it's a little cushion where I can have some space and it doesn't die. But I've talked to a lot of great bass players who like the hi-hat thing. I really don't like that. It's too thin for me. It's like I said there's already no support 'cause there's no bass. A piano player who knows what the hell he's doing — so at least let me get a ride cymbal.

MR: Do you actually tell the drummer that?

NC: Oh yeah. All the time. I'll let them do what they do and then, and 80% of the time they do it because once again it's some school shit. That's what a bass solo's for, I've got to go to a hi-hat because that's what they taught me at Berklee in Room 111 you know or

whatever. It's like no man, just play what feels right. And most of the drummers do that after I ask, just go switch to the ride, they'll switch to the ride. It works out.

MR: I appreciate your passion about that. I once remember writing a little blog about why are there all those bass player solo jokes. Like why? And I was sort of saying, I mean I understand what you're saying like well everything disappears except for the one poor guy up there and now he's got to carry the whole thing.

NC: Yes. And I commit myself to making other people sound good. That's what's so frustrating about it. It's funny actually. You've just got to laugh at it.

MR: And, but usually you're last, right?

NC: Right. But I'll say this, like bass solos are great and all, and I like to solo sometimes, and I enjoy a good bass solo, but that's not how I judge a bass player. Like actually I really don't care. I mean sometimes I do want to solo, but some nights I don't want to solo at all. I mean my job is to swing the band. And you know that's what a real bass player should take pride in. So if a guy can solo his ass off but he's not swinging, he's not playing good notes, he's not doing his job. You know that's not impressive to me.

MR: Yeah I have to say that I've played with a few bass players who I feel like telling them I think you're playing the wrong instrument. You really want to be a saxophone player.

NC: Yeah or a guitar player or whatever. Right.

MR: And you can tell.

NC: It's true.

MR: There's a certain amount of, not humility, of just taking pleasure and pride in what you said, swinging the band.

NC: Yeah. Kind of like the offensive line in football you know. Like kind of do the job.

MR: Is playing in the studio, making a record, how is it different from playing a gig?

NC: Well I try to play more in tune, I try to be more conscious of playing in tune. You know it's tough, it depends man. That's a good question because I always used to, I still approach it some — when I go in the studio if I'm making a record, it depends on the recording but I always try to underplay. You know I try to play the right thing you know. But I would try to err on the side of underplaying, playing more simpler, not overplaying, not playing a bunch of dumb stuff you know, because it would — but as I've gotten older, now I just kind of go in and hit hard and wish it well. I mean it depends on the scenario I guess. Like if I'm doing a Harry Connick record that's going to be really — something that has to be really clean you know, it depends on, it kind of depends on the situation. But ultimately it shouldn't really affect you at all. You should just go — you should just go hit it.

MR: Yeah. You have records that you've been on that, well first of all do you listen to the records that you've played on?

NC: Sometimes. I mean, not really. I mean I'll listen to it when it first comes out or whatever, but not really. And then sometimes you go back and listen. But no. I don't like to listen to myself too much. I mean I'll check it out if it comes out on a record but, I like to listen to myself occasionally, even if it's a live gig and someone tapes it, you know just to kind of check in. But people get into that, you know you can get too into, I don't know, I just don't like to listen to myself. A lot of times you think you sounded great one night and I'll hear it and I'll be like damn that sounded like shit. And vice versa. Some nights I think I had a bad night and I'll listen to a tape and I'll be like oh, actually it's kind of killing. So I don't know, there's a certain folly to all of that.

MR: Do you think you have ways of moving from one chord change to the next that might distinguish you from other bass players?

NC: Well it would depend on the bass player, but no. I mean no. I just try to walk pretty bass lines that outline the harmony of the chord. Like Israel Crosby, and I did study with Ron Carter for a while and he was very helpful in that regard. I just try to play pretty stuff. I mean but no, I mean I'm not any kind of innovator harmonically or anything — I mean everything's been done. I don't know.

MR: Everything's been done.

NC: There's only so many things you can do — I mean there's millions of different, you know, ways to play a bass line, a blues bass line, but no, I just try to be pretty and have a big sound and swing the band.

MR: Well that's a good philosophy.

NC: Yeah.

MR: What's in the near future besides playing at Hamilton College tomorrow?

NC: Well I just got done with the week with Harry Connick. He's got a new Cole Porter thing, show that he's putting together and a record coming out, and then I'm working on this soundtrack for this movie, and just a bunch of local gigs around New York, some stuff with my trio, and tomorrow night.

MR: How long have you been with Harry Connick?

NC: A long time.

MR: I wonder if you played in Utica because he was here a number of years ago.

NC: Yeah. I've been with him almost like twenty years or something.

MR: Yeah. That was the first time I saw a band using —

NC: Oh the computer screens?

MR: Computer charts, yeah. I remember it was a great concert.

NC: Yeah, he's a bad dude.

MR: How do you like to get recorded in the studio?

NC: Well I mean I'm not an expert on mics and stuff, but usually what I do is take my bass — well it depends on how we're doing it, if I'm isolated or not, but even if I'm not, because once again I use a pick-up, I like to get a corner kind of, and have the bass in the corner. It kind of reverberates the sound. But it depends on the engineer and all that stuff.

MR: Do you have any other interests besides playing the bass?

NC: I like water sports — no I'm just kidding. I mean I like to read history, I like baseball, the Cardinals.

MR: The St. Louis Cardinals?

NC: Yeah.

MR: Yeah I was a Cardinals fan. Stan Musial.

NC: Oh yeah, well did you grow up with KMOX radio?

MR: I used to hear them in Rochester, and the Rochester Red Wings used to be the St. Louis Cardinals farm team.

NC: Did you see some guys on the way up?

MR: Yeah, they would come once a year and play and I remember seeing Stan Musial.

NC: He played in four different decades, Stan Musial.

MR: Yeah right. Well I look forward to hearing you tomorrow.

NC: Thank you.

MR: And see how you interact with everybody, you and I think David I suspect get along pretty well.

NC: We fight like cats and dogs, that bitch. I'm just kidding. Thank you man.

MR: Thank you very much.

NC: Appreciate it.